



UniNotify

A Serverless Student Announcement & Notification System on AWS

CE308 – Cloud Computing | Project Report | GIKI Spring 2026

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1. Introduction

UniNotify is a fully serverless, cloud-native announcement system built entirely on Amazon Web Services (AWS). The system allows faculty and administrators at GIKI to send structured announcements to targeted student audiences through a clean web interface. Announcements are stored permanently in a NoSQL database, delivered instantly via email notifications, and the entire backend operates without a single managed server.

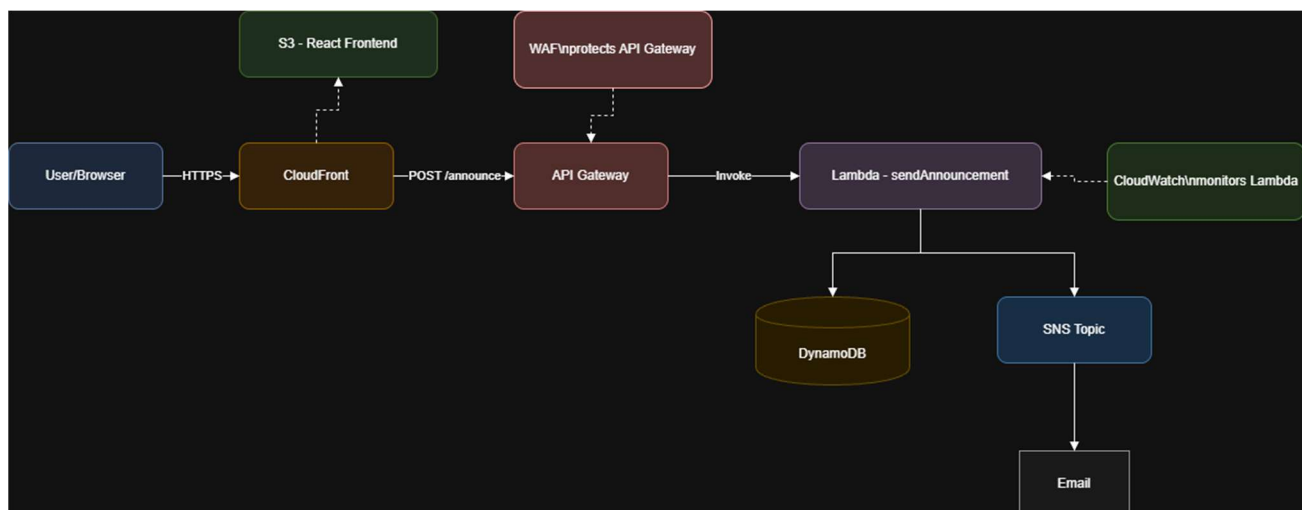
This project was developed as part of CE308 Cloud Computing to demonstrate practical mastery of AWS services, serverless architecture, REST API design, NoSQL databases, cloud security, and content delivery — all topics explicitly covered in the CE308 weekly syllabus.

2. Problem Statement

GIKI departments currently rely on WhatsApp groups and informal email threads for announcements. These methods are unstructured, offer no delivery guarantee, cannot target specific audiences, and leave no persistent record of communications. UniNotify replaces this with a structured, cloud-backed solution where every announcement is stored permanently with a unique ID and timestamp, delivered reliably to the correct audience, and accessible through a professional web interface — at zero cost under AWS Free Tier usage.

3. System Architecture

UniNotify follows a serverless, event-driven architecture composed of six AWS services connected in a linear pipeline. There is no EC2 instance, no web server, and no database engine to manage. Every component is fully managed by AWS and scales automatically.



3.1 Data Flow

The complete flow for a single announcement submission works as follows:

1. Faculty opens the CloudFront URL in their browser.
2. CloudFront fetches the React application files from the private S3 bucket and serves them.
3. Faculty fills in the title, selects an audience (e.g. CE Department), types a message, and clicks Send.
4. The React app sends a POST request to the API Gateway endpoint /announce with the form data as JSON.
5. WAF inspects the request, checks against the Core Rule Set, and passes it through if safe.
6. API Gateway invokes the Lambda function sendAnnouncement with the full request.
7. Lambda validates the input, writes the record to DynamoDB, and publishes to the correct SNS topic.
8. SNS emails every confirmed subscriber of that topic within seconds.
9. CloudWatch automatically logs the Lambda invocation and updates the dashboard.

3.2 Service Overview

AWS Service	Role in UniNotify	CE308 Topic
S3	Hosts the React frontend as static files	SaaS model (Week 2)
CloudFront	CDN — serves frontend globally, secures S3	Content delivery (Week 12)
API Gateway	REST endpoint that receives form submissions	REST protocols (Week 5)
Lambda	Serverless backend — validates, stores, notifies	Serverless / PaaS (Week 13)
DynamoDB	NoSQL database storing all announcements	Non-relational DB (Week 10)
SNS	Sends targeted email notifications per audience	Event-driven arch (Week 4)
IAM	Least-privilege permissions for Lambda	Security (Week 11)
CloudWatch	Logs, dashboard, and error alarms	Monitoring (Week 11)
WAF	Firewall protecting the API Gateway	Cloud security (Week 11)

4. Implementation

4.1 S3 & CloudFront — Frontend Hosting

The React frontend was built using Create React App and compiled into a static build folder. This folder was uploaded to a private S3 bucket with all public access blocked. A CloudFront distribution was created pointing to this bucket using Origin Access Control (OAC), which generates a bucket policy allowing only CloudFront to read from S3. Users access the application exclusively through the CloudFront URL — they never interact with S3 directly. This architecture is more secure than direct S3 hosting and delivers the frontend faster globally through CloudFront's edge network.

Objects (8)
🔄
📄 Copy S3 URI
📄 Copy URL
⬇️ Download
🔗 Open ↗️
Delete

Objects are the fundamental entities stored in Amazon S3. You can use [Amazon S3 inventory](#) to get a list of all objects in your bucket. [Learn more](#)

☐	Name	Type	Last modified	Size	Storage class
☐	index.html	html	April 30, 2026, 20:22:43 (UTC+05:00)	644.0 B	Standard
☐	logo192.png	png	April 30, 2026, 20:22:44 (UTC+05:00)	5.2 KB	Standard
☐	logo512.png	png	April 30, 2026, 20:22:47 (UTC+05:00)	9.4 KB	Standard
☐	manifest.json	json	April 30, 2026, 20:22:49 (UTC+05:00)	492.0 B	Standard
☐	robots.txt	txt	April 30, 2026, 20:22:50 (UTC+05:00)	67.0 B	Standard
☐	static/	Folder	-	-	-

Distributions (1)
Info
🔄
Enable
Disable
Delete

Filter type
All distributions ▼

☐	ID	Status	Descrip...	Type	Domai...	Alterna..
☐	E1O13ODGTQXTR	🟢 Enabled	-	Standard	d13lr...	-

4.2 API Gateway — REST Endpoint

A REST API named UniNotifyAPI was created in API Gateway with a single resource /announce and a POST method. Lambda Proxy Integration was enabled so that the full HTTP request is forwarded to Lambda unchanged. CORS was enabled on the resource to allow the React frontend running on a different domain (CloudFront) to make requests to the API. The API was deployed to a production stage named prod, generating the invoke URL used by the frontend.

The screenshot displays the AWS API Gateway console interface. It is divided into two main sections: 'Resources' and 'Stages'.

Resources Section:

- Resources List:** Shows a tree view with a root '/' and a child resource '/announce'. The '/announce' resource is selected and shows two methods: 'OPTIONS' and 'POST'.
- Resource details:** For the '/announce' resource, the path is '/announce' and the Resource ID is 'iygzxc'. Buttons for 'Delete' and 'Update documentation' are visible.
- Methods (2):** A table lists the methods for the resource:

	Method type ▲	Integration type ▼	Authorization
☐	OPTIONS	Mock	None
☐	POST	Lambda	None

Stages Section:

- Stages List:** Shows a single stage named 'prod'.
- Stage details:** For the 'prod' stage, the stage name is 'prod'. The 'Cache cluster' is 'Inactive' and 'Default method-level caching' is also 'Inactive'. The 'Rate' is 10000 and the 'Burst' is 5000. The 'Invoke URL' is <https://ms84vqng5l.execute-api.eu-north-1.amazonaws.com/prod>.

4.3 Lambda — Serverless Backend

The Lambda function `sendAnnouncement` was written in Python 3.12 and serves as the entire backend of the application. It performs three operations on every invocation: input validation, DynamoDB write, and SNS publish. The function uses a `TOPIC_MAP` dictionary to route announcements to the correct SNS topic based on the audience selected in the form. This means selecting CE Department sends only to CE students, Faculty sends only to faculty, and so on. The function handles CORS preflight `OPTIONS` requests and returns appropriate error responses for invalid input.

The screenshot displays the AWS Lambda console interface for the `sendAnnouncement` function. The top navigation bar includes tabs for **Code**, **Test**, **Monitor**, **Configuration**, **Aliases**, and **Versions**. The **Code source** tab is active, showing a code editor with the `lambda_function.py` file. The code includes imports for `json`, `boto3`, and `uuid`, and uses `boto3` to interact with `dynamodb` and `sns`. The `TABLE_NAME` is set to `'Announcements'`. Below the code editor, the **Runtime settings** section shows the function is configured with `Python 3.12` runtime, `lambda_function.lambda_handler` as the handler, and `x86_64` architecture. The **Executing function: succeeded** status is shown with a green checkmark, and the **Details** section displays the function's response as a JSON object:

```
{
  "statusCode": 200,
  "headers": {
    "Access-Control-Allow-Origin": "*"
  },
  "body": "{\"message\": \"Announcement sent to All Students!\"}"
}
```

4.4 DynamoDB — Persistent Storage

A DynamoDB table named Announcements was created with on-demand capacity mode. The partition key is id (a UUID generated by Lambda on each invocation) and the sort key is created_at (an ISO 8601 UTC timestamp). Every announcement submitted through the form is stored as an item in this table with all five fields: id, created_at, title, message, and audience. On-demand mode was chosen because it scales automatically with no capacity planning required and is cost-free under Free Tier usage levels.

Table: Announcements - Items returned (11)


Actions ▼
Create item

Scan started on May 09, 2026, 12:13:32

< 1 > | 

☐	id (String) ▼	created_at (String) ▼	audience ▼	
☐	8626b942-b4fe-4cfd-...	2026-05-05T07:07:09.7...	All Students	r
☐	4de7a3c1-f297-412a-...	2026-05-09T07:11:32.8...	All Students	H
☐	9e640bc7-8d8b-4f80-...	2026-04-28T18:35:32.6...	All Students	T
☐	2c8b5afe-9998-4d80-...	2026-05-05T07:09:12.1...	All Students	M
☐	1c3d509e-6b64-44a0-...	2026-05-07T13:52:07.5...	Faculty	T
☐	22ef4e17-7f9d-49b5-...	2026-05-08T17:38:58.7...	CE Depart...	l

4.5 SNS — Targeted Email Notifications

Five SNS topics were created corresponding to the five audience options in the form: uninotify-all-students, uninotify-ce-department, uninotify-cs-department, uninotify-final-year, and uninotify-faculty. Each topic has email subscriptions for the relevant recipients. Every subscriber confirmed their subscription via the AWS confirmation email. When Lambda calls sns.publish() with the correct topic ARN, SNS delivers the announcement email to all confirmed subscribers of that topic within seconds.

The screenshot displays the AWS SNS console interface. The top section, titled 'Topics (7)', shows a list of seven topics, all of type 'Standard'. The topics are: uninotify-alerts, uninotify-all-students, uninotify-announcements, uninotify-ce-department, uninotify-cs-department, uninotify-faculty, and uninotify-final-year. Each topic has a unique ARN. Below this, the 'Subscriptions' tab is selected, showing two subscriptions for the 'uninotify-all-students' topic. Both subscriptions are confirmed and use the EMAIL protocol. The endpoints are u2023385@giki.edu.pk and u2023694@giki.edu.pk.

Name	Type	ARN
uninotify-alerts	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-all-students	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-announcements	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-ce-department	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-cs-department	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-faculty	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...
uninotify-final-year	Standard	arn:aws:sns:eu-north-1:4124901608...

ID	Endpoint	Status	Protocol
1f777629-9b49-4437-b...	u2023385@giki.edu.pk	Confirmed	EMAIL
913c8635-447e-4caa-9c...	u2023694@giki.edu.pk	Confirmed	EMAIL

4.6 IAM — Least Privilege Security

A custom IAM execution role named uninotify-lambda-role was created for Lambda. Rather than using broad managed policies, a least-privilege inline policy was attached that grants only the three permissions Lambda actually needs: dynamodb:PutItem on the Announcements table, sns:Publish on all five UniNotify topics, and CloudWatch Logs permissions. This follows the principle of least privilege from the AWS Shared Responsibility Model — Lambda cannot access any other DynamoDB table, SNS topic, or AWS service.

Permissions policies (2) [Info](#)

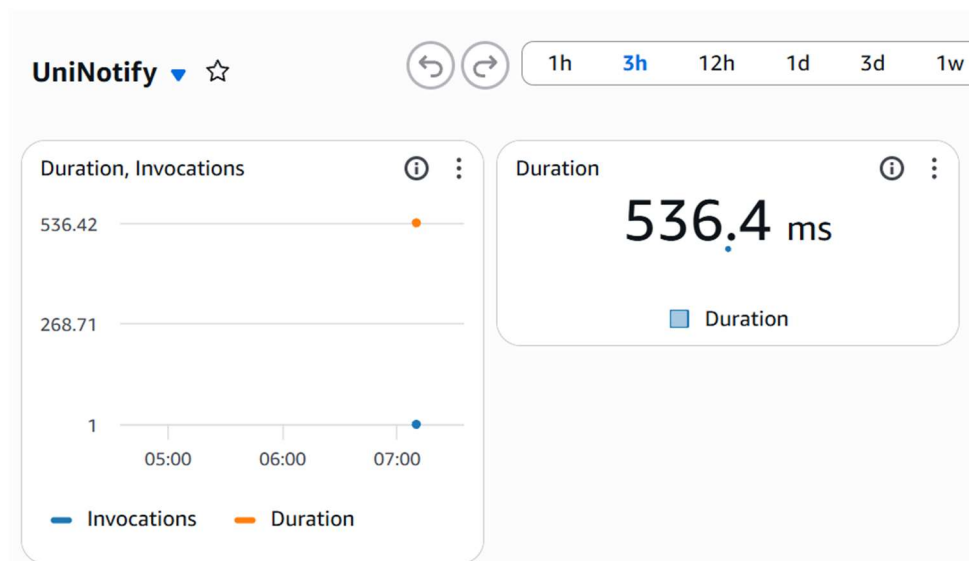
You can attach up to 10 managed policies.

Filter by Type: All types

☐	Policy name ↗	Type	Attached entities
☐	uninotify-least-privilege	Customer inline	0
☐	uninotify-policy	Customer inline	0

4.7 CloudWatch — Monitoring & Alarms

CloudWatch automatically captures logs from every Lambda invocation without any additional configuration, because Lambda writes to CloudWatch using the permissions in its IAM role. A custom dashboard named UniNotify was created showing Lambda invocations and duration over time. A CloudWatch Alarm was configured to monitor the Lambda error metric and trigger if errors exceed two within a five-minute window, publishing an alert to a separate SNS topic uninotify-alerts subscribed to the team's emails.



Create log stream

🔍 *Filter log streams or try prefix search*

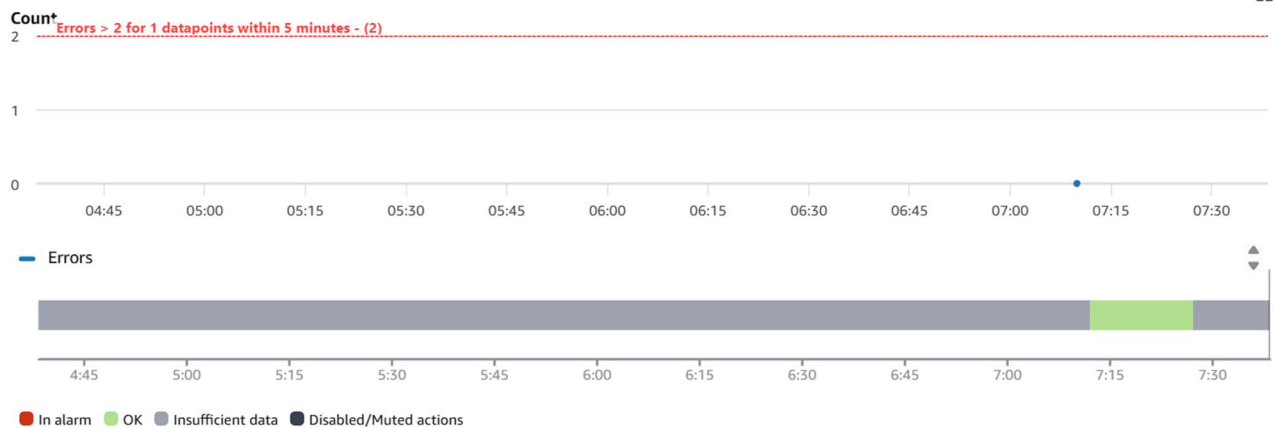
☐ Show expired

▼ | Last event time

2026/04/27/[\$LATEST]cbe9e48a02734736afef108f3276f2a6 2026-04-27 18:41:12 (UTC)



 Investigate



4.8 WAF — API Protection

AWS WAF was configured and attached to the UniNotifyAPI prod stage. A Web ACL named UniNotifyWAF was created with two rules: the AWS Managed Core Rule Set which automatically blocks common web exploits including SQL injection and cross-site scripting, and a custom rate-based rule that blocks any IP address exceeding 100 requests within a five-minute window. WAF inspects every request before it reaches API Gateway, providing a security layer between the public internet and the Lambda function.

UniNotifyWAF

[↓ JSON](#)

Description

WAF protection for UniNotify API Gateway

ARN

 `arn:aws:wafv2:eu-no...`

Id

 `51285fc6-1c32-4...`[Manage details](#)[Manage rules](#)[Manage custom response bodies](#)[Manage resources](#)[View dashboard, logs and sampled requests](#)[View AI traffic analysis *new*](#)[Configure logging and sampled requests](#)

5. Frontend Application

The frontend is a React 18 single-page application built with Create React App. It presents a form with three fields: announcement title (text input), audience (dropdown with five options), and message (textarea). On submission, Axios sends a POST request to the API Gateway invoke URL. The UI displays a green success message when the announcement is sent, or a red error message if the request fails. The application is intentionally simple and functional — the value of the project lies in the cloud architecture, not the UI complexity.



Send announcements to students instantly via email.

Title

e.g. Lab cancelled tomorrow

Audience

All Students

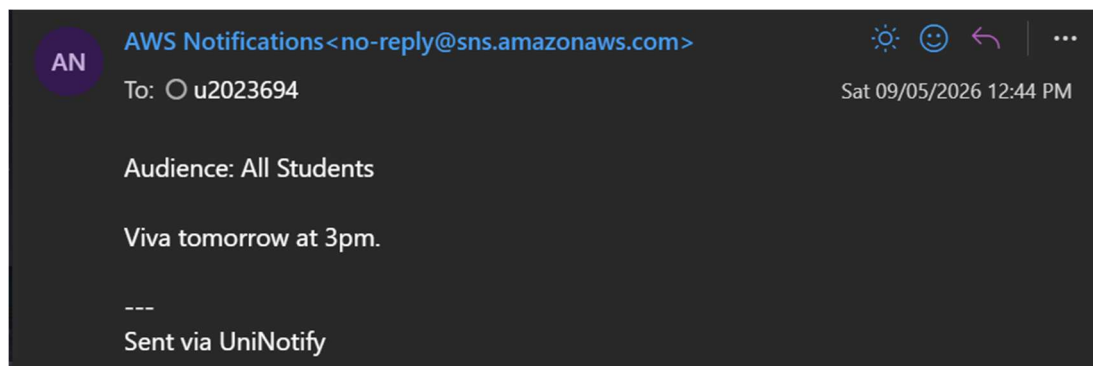
Message

Type your announcement here...

Send Announcement

Send Announcement

Announcement sent to All Students!



6. Testing & Verification

The system was tested at three levels: unit testing of the Lambda function using the built-in Lambda test console, integration testing using PowerShell curl commands against the API Gateway endpoint, and end-to-end testing through the live CloudFront URL.

Test	Method	Expected Result	Status
Lambda unit test	Lambda console test event	Status 200, record in DynamoDB	Pass
API Gateway integration	PowerShell POST request	JSON success response	Pass
CORS validation	Browser form submission	No CORS errors in console	Pass
DynamoDB write	Explore items after submission	New item with UUID and timestamp	Pass
SNS email delivery	Check inbox after submission	Email arrives within 30 seconds	Pass
Audience routing	Submit for each audience option	Email to correct topic only	Pass
CloudWatch logging	Check log streams after test	Invocation log visible	Pass
WAF attachment	WAF console	UniNotifyAPI listed as resource	Pass

7. CLO Mapping

CLO	Description	How UniNotify Satisfies It
CLO 1	Understand core cloud computing services	Architecture covers IaaS, PaaS, SaaS, serverless, NoSQL, CDN, event-driven patterns across 9 AWS services
CLO 2	Analyze and apply cloud-based solutions	Designed and deployed a working multi-service serverless system solving a real problem with measurable outcomes
CLO 3	Develop practitioner skills on AWS	Hands-on configuration of Lambda, API Gateway, DynamoDB, SNS, S3, CloudFront, IAM, CloudWatch, and WAF

8. Challenges & Solutions

- CORS errors on first browser submission — resolved by enabling CORS on the API Gateway resource and ensuring the Lambda function returns Access-Control-Allow-Origin: * in every response header including error responses.
- SNS emails not arriving — caused by team members not clicking the AWS confirmation link. Resolved by re-sending confirmation emails from the SNS console and confirming all subscriptions before testing.
- Lambda unable to write to DynamoDB — caused by the IAM role not yet having DynamoDB permissions. Resolved by attaching the inline policy with the correct table ARN.
- CloudFront returning 403 Forbidden — caused by the S3 bucket policy not being updated after OAC creation. Resolved by pasting the CloudFront-generated bucket policy into S3 permissions.
- React app showing blank page on CloudFront — caused by uploading the public/ folder instead of the build/ folder. Resolved by running npm run build and re-uploading the correct folder.

9. Cost Analysis

All services used in UniNotify fall within AWS Free Tier limits for the duration of this project. The only exception is WAF which is not covered by Free Tier.

Service	Free Tier Limit	Our Usage	Cost
Lambda	1M requests/month	< 200 requests	\$0.00
DynamoDB	25GB storage + 25 RCU/WCU	< 1MB, < 10 writes	\$0.00
SNS	1,000 email notifications/month	< 50 emails	\$0.00
API Gateway	1M calls/month (12 months)	< 200 calls	\$0.00
S3	5GB storage (12 months)	~5MB	\$0.00
CloudFront	1TB transfer/month (12 months)	< 1MB	\$0.00
CloudWatch	10 metrics + 5GB logs free	Well within limits	\$0.00
WAF	Not Free Tier	1 Web ACL + 1 rule	~\$6/month
Total			~\$6/month

Note: WAF will be deleted immediately after the project demonstration to avoid ongoing charges. All other services will remain active at zero cost.

10. Conclusion

UniNotify successfully demonstrates a production-grade serverless architecture on AWS that solves a real problem for GIKI students and faculty. The project integrates nine AWS services into a cohesive, working application that covers the full breadth of CE308 course content — from SaaS and PaaS service models to REST API design, serverless computing, NoSQL databases, content delivery, cloud security, IAM, and monitoring.

The system performs reliably: announcements are stored permanently in DynamoDB, delivered via email within seconds through SNS, and the entire backend runs without any server management. The audience routing system ensures the correct recipients receive each announcement. CloudWatch provides full observability and WAF provides security hardening at the API layer.

This project gave the team hands-on experience with the AWS services that power real-world applications, and demonstrated how serverless architecture can deliver a complete, scalable solution with minimal cost and complexity compared to traditional EC2-based deployments.